

Morning Edition

Friday, 11 September 2026

Ten stories curated through your lens on ocean governance, hydrospatial science, and SIDS equity.

JUMP TO STORY

01 ⚡ A Fund That Skips the Income Test

02 ⚡ Two Mapping Rooms, Five Weeks Out

03 The Paradox

⚡ ACTIONABLE – APPLICATION OPEN

A fund that doesn't run the income test that keeps locking Seychelles out

The Commonwealth's new COP29-backed SIDS fund uses Commonwealth membership, not income classification, as its eligibility test, which is the one filter that has never worked against Seychelles.

STORY NOTES

The Commonwealth Secretariat and Azerbaijan's COP29 Presidency have opened a standing fund for the 25 Commonwealth Small Island Developing States, Seychelles among them. It totals US\$5 million over five years, with an initial US\$2 million already disbursed. Of that first tranche, US\$1 million backs two flagship projects: implementing the Apia Commonwealth Ocean Declaration, and delivering AI and space data solutions for climate action.

Government-level grants run up to US\$200,000 per project, covering climate resilience, ocean health, and sustainable energy. The Apia Ocean Declaration project's own scope, ocean-climate work, blue finance access, marine protection, plastic reduction, reads like a HARMONiSE workplan someone else wrote first. Applications go through national government, so the play is getting SHORE named as technical partner in whatever Seychelles submits, the same route you used to sit on the other side of at the Department of Blue Economy.

<https://thecommonwealth.org/news/commonwealth-and-cop29-presidency-invite-commonwealth-sids-submit-climate-action-proposals>

STORY ARTICLE

Most ocean climate finance never reaches the government that needs it. It stalls in regional facilities, gets absorbed into larger multilateral windows, or requires co-financing structures a finance ministry of a handful of staff cannot service. This fund is worth reading closely because it is deliberately narrow in a way that avoids that trap.

The structure: US\$5 million committed over five years by the Commonwealth Secretariat and Azerbaijan's COP29 Presidency. An initial US\$2 million has already moved, with US\$1 million of that ring-fenced for two flagship projects chosen at Commonwealth level, implementing the Apia Commonwealth Ocean Declaration and delivering AI and space data solutions for climate action. The remaining balance is open for direct government applications from any of the 25 Commonwealth SIDS, up to US\$200,000 per project.

Read the Apia Ocean Declaration project's scope carefully. It funds ocean restoration and sustainable use, closing the ocean-climate nexus gap, expanded blue finance access, stronger marine protection, and reduced marine plastic pollution. Every one of those five areas overlaps directly with a HARMONiSE workstream or an Ocean Mapping Hub deliverable already under design at

SHORE. The fund was not built around Seychelles specifically. The fit is close enough that it should not need forcing.

Here is the eligibility detail that should actually catch attention, more than the dollar figure. The qualifying test is Commonwealth SIDS membership, not income classification. That is the one filter that has never worked against Seychelles the way GNI-based screening does everywhere else, the mechanism behind the High-Income SIDS Paradox that keeps closing GCF and GEF doors regardless of Seychelles's real exposure. A fund that ignores income classification entirely and asks only whether a state belongs to the group is, structurally, a rare thing.

The constraint that matters more than eligibility is who applies. The grant flows to national government, not to an institute or NGO directly. That means the actual work over the next weeks is not technical scoping, it is getting in front of whichever unit inside the Department of Blue Economy or the Ministry now owns this file, before someone else does, and offering SHORE as the technical partner who turns a concept note into a fundable project design. That access is not generic for you. It runs through relationships built during your own tenure there, and it is worth using directly rather than waiting for a public call for partners that may never be published.

The counterargument is scale. Two million dollars split across 25 states, with a chunk already earmarked for flagship projects, is a thin pool, and a state that moves fast on its concept note captures a disproportionate share of what remains. Seychelles has won smaller, less obviously aligned funding before. This one carries a larger prize and a shorter runway, which argues for drafting the two-page concept note this month rather than next quarter.

<https://thecommonwealth.org/news/commonwealth-and-cop29-presidency-invite-commonwealth-sids-submit-climate-action-proposals>

Two rooms, five and six weeks out, where the regional model gets built

Seabed 2030's two flagship autumn events are where a Western Indian Ocean regional hub model gets tested in practice, and the Ocean Mapping Hub concept is stronger for having watched one operate before pitching its own.

STORY NOTES

A Symposium in Cartagena, Colombia, runs 8 to 9 October, bringing the global ocean mapping community together to exchange methods and coordinate across the four Seabed 2030 Regional Centers. The Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting and Data Sprint follows, 20 to 22 October in Kuala Lumpur, a working session built around participants bringing actual survey data and leaving with real coordination decisions.

Neither event covers the Western Indian Ocean directly. Both are the closest existing model to what the Ocean Mapping Hub needs to become as a regional coordination node, and the people running the Indo-Pacific hub structure are worth knowing before building an equivalent from scratch.

<https://seabed2030.org/>

STORY ARTICLE

The bathymetric map of the world ocean floor is still short of complete, and Seabed 2030's two flagship autumn events are where the actual coordination work of

closing that gap happens, not the fundraising or the press release.

The Cartagena Symposium, 8 and 9 October, is the broader of the two: a global gathering meant to exchange knowledge, coordinate methods across the four Seabed 2030 Regional Centers, and advance shared understanding of the seafloor as a managed environment, not just a dataset. It is the room where the Regional Center model itself gets discussed and refined, which matters directly, because that model is close to what a Western Indian Ocean hub would need to replicate.

The Kuala Lumpur meeting, 20 to 22 October, is narrower and more useful. It is described explicitly as a data sprint: participants arrive with actual survey data and gaps identified, and leave with actual coordination decisions about who surveys what next, not a panel discussion about coordination in the abstract. The Indo-Pacific framing sits geographically adjacent to, but does not include, the Western Indian Ocean. That adjacency is worth exploiting rather than treating as exclusion. A regional hub model built for Indo-Pacific coordination is a working template, and its architects are the people worth knowing before the Ocean Mapping Hub tries to stand up an equivalent structure alone.

GEBCO's own most recent grid was built from all four existing Regional Centers' contributed data. That is the current best-available baseline against which the Western Indian Ocean's own gap should be measured, and both October events put the people who built it in one place at the same time.

The practical question is not whether there is a paper ready to present at either event. There is not, and none is needed yet. The question is whether a short inquiry to either organizing committee, framed around the Ocean Mapping Hub's regional coordination ambitions, secures a seat as an observer or a listed regional contact for the Western Indian Ocean. That costs one email and produces either a useful relationship or nothing lost.

The honest complication is travel cost and timing. Both events land within a five-to-six-week window from now, tight for planning international travel around an already busy calendar. Weigh Cartagena's broader networking value against Kuala Lumpur's more concrete working format if only one trip is realistic, and default to whichever is easier to combine with existing SHORE or Shorelines-related travel this quarter.

SHARE OF THE GLOBAL TUNA CATCH THAT RUNS THROUGH SEYCHELLES'S WATERS

1/5

The paradox has a cleaner number now

Seychelles's blue economy now funds Africa's highest GDP per capita, and that success is exactly the mechanism that keeps pricing Seychelles out of the concessional climate finance its physical vulnerability still qualifies for.

STORY NOTES

Seychelles sits in the world's second largest tuna basin, accounting for roughly a fifth of the global catch, with Port Victoria handling most of what is landed regionally. Tuna, tourism, and a pioneering blue bond sit behind Africa's highest GDP per capita and a falling public debt ratio. The IMF projects 3.4 percent GDP growth for 2027 as the economy scales beyond fisheries and tourism into newer sectors.

None of that wealth changes underlying exposure: a landmass under 460 square kilometres, an economy concentrated in three sectors, direct exposure to sea level rise and cyclone intensification. India's June state visit, nineteen bilateral outcomes including a new roadmap on marine resource cooperation, reads as one more bilateral relationship substituting for the multilateral concessional access the GDP number closes off.

This is the case study The High-Income SIDS Paradox has needed: the tuna share, the GDP figure, and the growth projection sitting in one place for the first time.

STORY ARTICLE

Every version of the High-Income SIDS Paradox argument needs one number a reader cannot wave away, and Seychelles just produced it. The country accounts for roughly a fifth of the global tuna catch inside the world's second largest tuna basin, with Port Victoria functioning as the regional hub for most of what gets landed. Tuna, tourism, and a debt-for-nature blue bond sit behind Africa's highest GDP per capita, and a public debt ratio that has fallen rather than climbed against the regional trend.

That is the success story. It is also the exact mechanism that produces the paradox. GDP per capita is the primary screen most multilateral climate funds use to determine concessional eligibility. Seychelles's blue economy success pushes that number high enough to route the country out of windows smaller, poorer island states can still access, even though nothing about the underlying vulnerability profile, extreme land scarcity, sectoral concentration, direct exposure to sea level rise and cyclone intensification, has changed because a GDP figure moved.

The IMF's growth projection sharpens the trajectory rather than complicating it. Analysts expect 3.4 percent growth in 2027 as the economy scales innovation-driven sectors beyond fisheries and tourism. Higher growth means a higher GDP per capita figure next year, which widens the concessional eligibility gap rather than closing it. On the metric multilateral finance actually uses, success makes the paradox worse, not better.

Read India's June state visit against that backdrop. Nineteen bilateral outcomes, spanning development finance, digital payments, maritime cooperation, and a new roadmap on marine resource cooperation, are not incidental diplomacy. They are one government substituting bilateral finance and cooperation for multilateral access the GDP screen has closed. Seychelles is not the only high-income SIDS doing this. It is simply the one with the sharpest data behind it this month.

The obvious counterargument deserves a direct answer rather than a dismissal: perhaps Seychelles should accept it no longer qualifies as finance-vulnerable and compete instead on private capital and blue bond structures. The blue bond has worked, genuinely. But a single well-structured bond is not a substitute for the concessional adaptation finance a state exposed to compounding climate risk actually needs, and the fact that the bond can be pointed to as evidence of financial sophistication is exactly what donors use to justify screening Seychelles out of the pool that funds adaptation infrastructure rather than blue innovation showcases.

This is the sharpest version of the Paradox argument yet: the tuna share, the GDP figure, and the growth trajectory, together, in one place, for the first time.

STORY_04.LOG

\$ sdb --accuracy=improved --zone=shallow_coastal

Two papers this year push satellite-derived bathymetry accuracy further in exactly the shallow coastal band where Seychelles's reef and nearshore mapping needs actually sit, and neither has made it into a HARMONiSE methodology review yet.

STORY NOTES

\$ A January review paper covers the current state of satellite-derived bathymetry across multi-sensor remote sensing: physics-based models, machine learning and deep learning approaches, and integration with ICESat-2 lidar altimetry as calibration data.

Separately, research published the same month shows spectral and temporal averaging of PlanetScope SuperDove imagery meaningfully improves SDB accuracy specifically in shallow coastal water, the depth band that matters most for reef and nearshore mapping. Sentinel-2 remains the workhorse for free, global-coverage SDB at 10 to 20 metre resolution with a five-day revisit.

Both papers are open access, worth reading before the next HARMONiSE methodology update.

STORY ARTICLE

Satellite-derived bathymetry has moved in five years from a niche technique validated against a handful of reference sites to something close to an operational baseline for shallow coastal mapping. Two pieces of research published in January move that baseline again, and both are directly relevant to how the SDB pipeline underneath HARMONiSE should actually run.

The first is a comprehensive review tracing the field's evolution: locally calibrated multispectral regression, the original SDB approach, through physics-based radiative transfer models, to the current generation of machine learning and deep learning methods, with particular attention to integrating ICESat-2's lidar altimetry as calibration and validation data. Its real contribution is not a new method but a map of which method suits which condition. Locally calibrated regression still wins for small, well-surveyed sites with strong in-situ data. Deep learning wins when the goal is transferability across a large, undersurveyed coastline with no local calibration data, precisely the Seychelles condition.

The second paper is narrower and more immediately useful. It shows that spectral and temporal averaging of PlanetScope SuperDove imagery, a commercial constellation with far higher revisit frequency than Sentinel-2, measurably improves SDB accuracy specifically in shallow coastal water. Shallow water has always been where SDB struggles most, since seafloor reflectance competes with surface glint, turbidity, and vegetation cover in the same narrow spectral band. A method that improves accuracy exactly there improves it where reef systems, seagrass beds, and nearshore navigation channels actually sit, which is most of what a Seychelles mapping programme needs resolved.

Sentinel-2 is not being displaced. It remains the right choice for free-tier, global-coverage baseline mapping at 10 to 20 metre resolution and a five-day revisit cycle. What the PlanetScope result suggests is a two-tier architecture: Sentinel-2 for broad coverage, targeted commercial tasking of higher-frequency imagery for the specific shallow-water zones where accuracy drives management decisions, reef health monitoring, MPA boundary definition, coastal infrastructure siting.

The honest complication is cost. PlanetScope tasking is not free, and a two-tier architecture assumes a budget line a single Sentinel-2 pipeline does not require. That is a real constraint for an institute SHORE's size, not a hypothetical one. But it is also exactly the kind of technical justification that belongs in a grant concept note, the Apia Ocean Declaration application included: a two-tier SDB architecture is a concrete, costed deliverable, not an abstract capacity-building line item, and concrete deliverables get funded.

Both papers are open access and worth a full read before the next internal HARMONiSE methodology update.

Sovereignty over data is sovereignty over how the ocean gets managed

“Sovereignty over data is sovereignty over how the ocean gets managed.”

Ocean Networks Canada is building Indigenous ocean data sovereignty protocols right now, and every principle they land on is a template SHORE can adapt before an external partner's default terms define the standard first.

STORY NOTES

Ocean Networks Canada is working with Indigenous communities to build protocols supporting Indigenous Peoples' sovereignty over their own ocean data, framed explicitly as part of decolonizing data acquisition and ownership in ocean science. It sits alongside an established international network, Indigenous data sovereignty groups now operating across the US, Canada, Aotearoa, Australia, the Pacific, and Scandinavia, coordinated through the Global Indigenous Data Alliance.

The Pacific Data Sovereignty Network is the closest existing model to what a Western Indian Ocean equivalent would need: a framework keeping regional ocean knowledge culturally grounded and locally controlled rather than defaulting to whichever external partner collected it first. Seychelles has never needed a formal ocean data sovereignty policy, mainly because SHORE has so far been the primary collector of its own hydrospatial data. That will not stay true once external partnerships and larger surveys scale.

<https://www.oceannetworks.ca/news-and-stories/stories/decolonizing-data/>

STORY ARTICLE

Data sovereignty is usually framed as an issue specific to Indigenous rights in settler-colonial states, which is accurate but incomplete. The underlying principle, that the party generating knowledge about a place should control how that knowledge gets used, shared, and monetized, applies with equal force to a small island state whose hydrospatial data has historically been collected, processed, and archived by whichever larger institution or foreign university funded the expedition.

Ocean Networks Canada's current work with Indigenous communities is worth studying as a working model, not an adjacent story. Their framing, decolonizing data acquisition and ownership in ocean science, describes practical protocols: who holds original survey data, what consent process governs its use in third-party research, how attribution and benefit-sharing work when external researchers build on locally collected data, what happens when a community wants a dataset withdrawn from external use. None of those questions are unique to Indigenous contexts. They are questions SHORE has never had to formally answer, because until now SHORE has mostly been both the collector and the primary user of its own data.

That condition is ending precisely because SHORE's work is succeeding. The Ocean Mapping Hub concept depends on external partnerships, university collaborations, larger survey campaigns, potentially the kind of autonomous-platform data-sharing arrangement Seabed 2030 is now piloting with Ulysses. Every one of those partnerships is a moment where the question of who controls the resulting data gets decided, either through a policy SHORE wrote in advance, or by default through whichever partner's standard data-sharing agreement gets signed first because no Seychelles-specific alternative existed to propose instead.

The Global Indigenous Data Alliance's CARE principles, Collective Benefit, Authority to Control, Responsibility, Ethics, were built for Indigenous contexts but translate cleanly to a small-state hydrospatial setting with almost no modification needed. Authority to Control is the piece missing from most existing marine research data-sharing agreements, which tend to default to open-access publication norms borrowed from

academic science rather than asking first whether the originating state retains a say in how its data gets used.

The counterargument worth naming directly: open data mandates exist for good reasons, and a Seychelles-specific sovereignty framework that reads as restrictive could complicate exactly the funding relationships, the Commonwealth fund covered elsewhere in this edition included, that SHORE needs to grow. That tension is real. The CARE framework's answer to it, that sovereignty and open science are not opposites, that authority to control includes the authority to choose openness, is the argument that resolves it. Building that policy now, before an external partner's default terms fill the vacuum, is cheaper than renegotiating a data-sharing agreement after the fact.

<https://www.oceannetworks.ca/news-and-stories/stories/decolonizing-data/>

Ten days out: the UN's first ocean-only finance forum

In ten days the UNFCCC holds its first Standing Committee on Finance forum built entirely around ocean and water finance, and the framing that wins in that room shows up in eligibility criteria eighteen months from now.

STORY NOTES

The 2026 Forum of the Standing Committee on Finance meets 21 and 22 September in Sydney, at the Sofitel Darling Harbour, under the theme Financing Climate Action for Water

STORY ARTICLE

Ocean finance has spent a decade being everyone's afterthought and no one's dedicated line item, folded into biodiversity funds not designed for coastal infrastructure or adaptation funds that

Systems and the Ocean. The programme was set at the SCF's fortieth meeting in June, bringing governments, climate funds, financial institutions, civil society, and the private sector into one room to argue over closing the ocean finance gap.

The forum's own background paper states plainly what SIDS delegations have argued for years: ocean-based climate action is underfunded relative to country needs, to rising loss and damage, and to the conditional ocean commitments countries have already written into their NDCs. SIDS receive only a small share of SDG14 funding and have asked for special treatment in access, given capacity constraints most large donors do not design around.

This is a forum, not a funding window, so there is nothing to apply for directly. But it sets the language that becomes the next funding window's eligibility criteria.

<https://unfccc.int/event/2026-forum-of-the-standing-committee-on-finance>

treat the ocean as a hazard rather than an asset. The UNFCCC dedicating an entire Standing Committee on Finance forum to water systems and the ocean, meeting in Sydney on 21 and 22 September, is the first formal acknowledgment at that level that the ocean needs its own financing conversation rather than a subsection of someone else's.

The forum's background paper is unusually direct about scale. It states that ocean-based climate action remains significantly underfunded relative to country needs, to rising loss and damage impacts, and to the conditional ocean commitments developing countries, most SIDS included, have already written into their Nationally Determined Contributions. That last point deserves attention: many SIDS structured their NDC ocean commitments explicitly as conditional on external finance arriving. When that finance does not show up, the country is left holding a commitment it made in good faith and cannot deliver alone.

The forum follows the June Ocean and Climate Change Dialogue in Bonn, where delegations pushed ocean-related climate finance as a formal means of implementation rather than a voluntary extra. The framing has shifted from the ocean matters for climate to the ocean needs a financing architecture, a more useful argument to be inside.

For SIDS, the evidence base is not encouraging. SDG14 receives one of the smallest shares of climate and development finance of any Sustainable Development Goal, despite covering the resource most SIDS economies depend on directly. SIDS have called for special treatment in access, arguing that standard co-financing and readiness requirements assume institutional capacity a finance ministry of a dozen staff does not have. That argument has been made before. What is new is a dedicated UNFCCC forum built specifically to hear it.

None of this produces a grant application this month. A forum does not disburse money. What it does is set the language that shows up eighteen months later in the eligibility criteria of the fund that does disburse money. Reading the background paper and submissions now, before the room in Sydney fills, is the cheapest way to shape that language rather than react to it once it is fixed.

Worth watching specifically who represents Indian Ocean SIDS in that room. Pacific delegations have historically been louder and better resourced at forums like this than their Indian Ocean counterparts, and that imbalance shapes whose framing wins.

In force is not the same as usable

BBNJ's first Conference of the Parties is likely to land before the year ends, and the high seas marine protected area nomination process it will adopt is being drafted right now, in a preparatory commission process that runs on exactly the technical input SIDS institutions rarely get invited to give.

STORY NOTES

The BBNJ Agreement crossed the 60-ratification threshold in September 2025 and entered into force on 17 January 2026. As of January, 83 countries had ratified it, including major maritime states such as China and Japan, alongside 145 signatures overall. It is the first legally binding framework governing marine biodiversity across the nearly half of the planet lying beyond any national jurisdiction.

Entry into force is the easy part. A preparatory commission is still working through the operational rules: how a country nominates a high seas marine protected area, how environmental impact assessments for high seas activity get conducted, how the funding mechanism and institutional staffing actually work. The treaty requires its first Conference of the Parties to convene within a year of entry into force, putting it toward the end of 2026.

None of the procedural detail is finalized yet, which is the actual opportunity.

<https://www.un.org/ola/en/node/1197>

S A treaty entering into force and a treaty being usable are two different events, and the gap between them is where the real work of ocean governance happens.

BBNJ, the High Seas Treaty, crossed its ratification threshold in September 2025 and came into force on 17 January 2026. That is the milestone everyone reported. It is also the less important one.

What matters more, and what almost nobody is writing about yet, is that the operational rules are still being drafted by a preparatory commission, and those rules will determine whether the framework does anything for hydrospatial equity or simply reproduces the same access asymmetries that already exist in territorial waters. Three procedural questions sit open. First, how does a country or coalition nominate a high seas marine protected area, and what data standard must that nomination meet. Second, how are environmental impact assessments for high seas activity structured, and who has the technical capacity to conduct one to the treaty's standard. Third, how is the funding mechanism and the treaty's own institutional staffing resourced, since a convention with no secretariat capacity exists on paper only.

Each of those three questions has a spatial data answer buried inside it. A high seas MPA nomination needs a bathymetric and ecological baseline. An environmental impact assessment needs the same. A funding mechanism that channels capacity-building resources needs to know which states can already produce that baseline data and which cannot. This is precisely the gap HARMONiSE was built to address in national waters. The high seas extension of that same problem is now being defined by a preparatory commission that has not, as far as public documentation shows, brought in hydrospatial specialists from SIDS institutions to weigh in on what a workable data standard should look like.

The first Conference of the Parties must convene within a year of entry into force, putting it toward the end of 2026, a matter of months away. Once the COP adopts nomination and assessment procedures, they are effectively locked for years, the way most treaty procedural annexes are.

The instinct is to treat this as premature: SHORE has no obvious formal channel into a UN preparatory commission, and the sensible move looks like waiting for procedures to be adopted and working within them once they exist. That sequencing is backwards. Procedural rules get easier to shape before adoption and nearly impossible to shape after. Preparatory commission processes typically run consultations and calls for input

from civil society and technical bodies specifically because they need technical expertise they do not have in-house. Finding that consultation channel now, while rules are still being drafted, costs a research afternoon. Finding it after the COP adopts final annexes costs nothing, because by then it no longer matters.

Your own delimitation work under the Joint Management Area with Mauritius is a directly relevant credential here, evidence of exactly the technical, jurisdiction-adjacent expertise a preparatory commission consultation is meant to draw in. That is a stronger opening than a cold submission from an institute with no prior track record in transboundary maritime governance would have.

See also: IOC-UNESCO, “BBNJ Agreement Successfully Ratified”; UN Division for Ocean Affairs and the Law of the Sea, agreement status and ratification tracker.

<https://www.un.org/ola/en/node/1197>

N ° 08

The eighth grid is out, and no one has checked what changed here

GEBCO_2026 is the new baseline every Ocean Mapping Hub coverage claim gets measured against, published five months ago, and nobody has checked yet what it actually changed for the Western Indian Ocean.

STORY NOTES

The GEBCO_2026 Grid was published in April, the eighth grid produced through the Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 Project. It augments the SRTM15+ base grid with gridded bathymetric datasets contributed by all four Seabed 2030 Regional Centers, folding in a year's worth of newly submitted survey data.

A new grid release is the moment to check what changed in a specific region's coverage, not just accept the global completion headline. Whether new multibeam

or crowdsourced submissions moved the needle for Seychelles's waters specifically is a short check against the previous grid version, and it has not been done.

<https://www.gebco.net/news/release-gebco2026-grid>

STORY ARTICLE

Every year Seabed 2030 publishes a new GEBCO grid, the headline is the same: global completion percentage ticks up, the story runs in the trade press, and most regional institutes move on without checking what the new grid actually changed in their own waters.

GEBCO_2026, published in April, is worth breaking that pattern for.

The grid's construction is straightforward: an SRTM15+ base, the standard global bathymetric interpolation model, augmented with gridded datasets contributed by each of the four Seabed 2030 Regional Centers. That structure matters directly for Seychelles, because it means grid accuracy in the Western Indian Ocean depends entirely on what data the relevant Regional Center had to contribute this year, not on some uniform global survey effort. A region with an active Regional Center pushing new multibeam and crowdsourced submissions gets meaningfully better with each annual release. A region without that active pipeline stays roughly flat, whatever the global completion headline says.

This is where the check that has not happened yet matters. Comparing GEBCO_2025 to GEBCO_2026 for Seychelles's Exclusive Economic Zone and the surrounding Western Indian Ocean shelf takes perhaps an afternoon: pull both grid versions, difference the coverage and resolution, and see whether last year's submissions, if there were any, actually moved the local picture. If they did, that is evidence the regional data pipeline is working and worth expanding. If they did not, that is the sharper finding: whatever bathymetric survey work happened in Seychelles's waters over the past year has not made it into the global grid at all, which is a data visibility problem worth raising directly with the relevant Regional Center.

There is a second reason this matters beyond the technical coverage question. Every funding pitch the Ocean Mapping Hub makes implicitly claims to be closing a data gap. The credibility of that claim rests on being able to say precisely what GEBCO_2026 does and does not capture for the Western Indian Ocean, in specific numbers, rather than gesturing at incomplete global coverage. A concept note that cites the exact percentage of

Seychelles's EEZ resolved to modern survey standard in GEBCO_2026, against the percentage two grid releases ago, is a materially stronger document than one that speaks generally about the mapping gap.

The Kuala Lumpur data sprint and the Cartagena Symposium, both covered elsewhere in this edition, are rooms where exactly this question, what did the new

grid actually change regionally, gets asked and answered informally among Regional Center staff. Walking into either room already knowing the answer for the Western Indian Ocean is a materially stronger position than walking in to ask it cold.

<https://www.gebco.net/news/release-gebco2026-grid>

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Autonomous systems just entered the bathymetric data chain

Seabed 2030 partnered with an autonomous ocean tech company this year, and that is the low-crew, low-cost survey capability that solves the exact constraint on how much of Seychelles's own waters SHORE can actually survey.

STORY NOTES

In July, the Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 Project announced a partnership with ocean technology company Ulysses to explore how autonomous surface and underwater systems can support the collection and sharing of bathymetric data. It sits alongside a broader shift toward autonomous and crowdsourced platforms supplementing traditional crewed survey vessels.

The barrier to Seychelles running more of its own multibeam survey work has never been technical knowledge. It has been vessel time and crew cost. Autonomous surface vehicles change that cost structure directly, and a Seabed 2030 partnership specifically exploring data-sharing protocols for autonomous platforms is worth watching for whatever standard eventually emerges, since that standard will likely become the one SHORE has to meet to contribute data upward into the global grid.

<https://www.gebco.net/>

STORY ARTICLE

The single biggest constraint on how much of Seychelles's own waters SHORE can survey directly has never been methodological. It is vessel time, and vessel time is expensive in exactly the way a small institute's budget cannot absorb: day rates for a crewed survey vessel, fuel, crew salaries, and the scheduling friction of coordinating a research cruise around weather windows and competing demands on the same vessel from fisheries or coast guard operations.

Autonomous surface vehicles change that arithmetic directly, which is why the July partnership between the Nippon Foundation-GEBCO Seabed 2030 Project and ocean technology company Ulysses is worth tracking closely rather than filing as a general industry trend piece. The stated goal is exploring how autonomous surface and underwater systems can support both the collection and the sharing of bathymetric data at Seabed 2030 scale. An autonomous surface vehicle running a multibeam survey line needs no crew berth, no comparable fuel budget, and can run missions on a schedule set by battery endurance and weather rather than crew availability. For an institute SHORE's size, that is the difference between a survey campaign being a multi-year fundraising project and being a deployable capability.

The part of this partnership worth watching closely is not the hardware, it is the data-sharing protocol that comes out of it. Seabed 2030 already coordinates data submission standards across its four Regional Centers for traditional survey platforms. An autonomous platform generates data differently: potentially continuous, potentially lower per-line accuracy depending on the sensor package,

from a much larger number of smaller, cheaper platforms rather than a handful of large research vessels. Whatever submission standard Seabed 2030 and Ulysses settle on for autonomous platform data will likely become the de facto standard any institute contributing autonomous-vehicle bathymetry to the global grid has to meet.

That has a very practical consequence. If SHORE is weighing whether an eventual Ocean Mapping Hub investment in autonomous survey capability is worth the capital cost, the answer depends heavily on whether the data that capability produces actually counts toward closing Seychelles's share of the global mapping gap, or sits outside whatever standard Seabed 2030 ends up requiring. Getting ahead of that standard, by tracking this partnership's outputs as they publish rather than after an equipment purchase is already made, is the cheaper way to find out.

The honest caveat: autonomous survey platforms are not a like-for-like substitute for crewed multibeam work in deep water or complex terrain, and nothing in this partnership suggests otherwise. The realistic use case is nearshore and shelf-depth survey, exactly the depth band where Seychelles has the most unresolved coverage and the least need for deep-water-capable equipment.

<https://www.gebco.net/>

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Sovereignty now runs through data infrastructure

The Geospatial World Forum built its entire 2026 theme around sovereignty running through data and infrastructure rather than borders, which is the exact argument behind hydrospatial equity, now validated on a far larger stage than Shorelines alone.

The Geospatial World Forum 2026 convened governments, technology firms, and development partners under the theme Sovereignty, Economy & Society, arguing that national sovereignty now depends as much on data access, digital infrastructure, and the capacity to convert information into action as on territorial control. The SDG Data Alliance presented specifically on building data foundations for resilient island futures at the same forum.

This is the science-to-policy pipeline argument stated at forum scale, in front of governments and technology companies rather than academic researchers: a state that cannot generate, control, or interpret its own spatial data is not fully sovereign over the space that data describes, whatever a map's political boundary shows.

Session material and the SDG Data Alliance's presentation, where available, are worth reviewing for the specific language being used, since matching it in the next funding pitch is cheaper than inventing new terminology from zero.

STORY ARTICLE

Two years of arguing that hydrospatial capacity is a sovereignty issue, not a technical nice-to-have, just got a considerably larger stage than Shorelines can offer alone. The Geospatial World Forum 2026 built its entire theme, Sovereignty, Economy & Society, around exactly that argument: sovereignty today extends beyond borders and depends on access to data, digital infrastructure, and the capacity to transform information into action.

That reframing is worth sitting with, because it stretches a term normally reserved for territorial and legal claims. A state can hold undisputed legal sovereignty over its Exclusive Economic Zone and still not control the primary knowledge base describing what is in it, because that knowledge, the bathymetric survey, the habitat map, the water quality baseline, was generated by an external research partner, processed on infrastructure the state does not own, and archived somewhere the state cannot easily retrieve it from. Legal sovereignty and data sovereignty are not the same thing, and the gap between them is exactly where SIDS hydrospatial capacity gaps live.

The SDG Data Alliance's presentation at the same forum, on building data foundations for resilient island futures, sharpens the point specifically for island states. It is a direct acknowledgment that the data infrastructure question is not an abstract governance concern but a concrete resilience issue: an island state's capacity to plan for sea level

rise, cyclone exposure, or fisheries management depends on a data foundation it actually controls, not one it borrows access to from whichever partner collected it.

The reason this forum matters beyond validating an argument already believed is audience. Geospatial World Forum draws governments and technology companies, the exact constituency that ends up writing the next generation of geospatial capacity-building grant criteria and technology partnership terms. When a framing like sovereignty depends on data infrastructure gets stated at that forum, in front of that audience, it has a real chance of showing up eighteen months later in how a donor scopes a call for proposals, or how a technology company structures a public-private ocean data partnership with a small state. Framing precedes funding criteria more often than the reverse.

The direct application for Shorelines is straightforward. The newsletter's core argument, that hydrospatial equity is a sovereignty question rather than a capacity-building afterthought, now has a citable, mainstream, non-academic venue making the identical case to a donor and government audience. That is a materially stronger anchor than another ocean governance journal article, precisely because it shows the framing has already crossed from academic literature into the rooms where funding decisions actually get made.

Session recordings and the SDG Data Alliance's presentation, where available, are worth reviewing directly for the specific language being used, since matching that language in the next funding pitch is cheaper than inventing new terminology that has to prove itself from zero.